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Navigating Campus Crisis: Empowering SAO in Decision-Making in Response to Global Uncertainties

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ABSTRACT
This study investigated experiences and decision-making strategies of Student Affairs Officers (SAOs) facing significant crisis at a Sino-foreign cooperative university during the COVID-19 pandemic. Using habitual decision-making and 4 R crisis management frameworks, the study examined how SAOs navigated crisis management, anticipated student needs, and exercised decision-making authority. Findings highlight the importance of empowering SAOs through shared governance and contingency planning to enhance their capacity for managing future crises and supporting sustainable internationalization.

The internationalization of Chinese higher education has progressed substantially, demonstrated by the growth of joint-venture universities, formally termed Sino-foreign cooperative education (SFCE) institutions (Zhang & Ling, 2022). Operating under "The Regulation on Chinese-Foreign Cooperation in Running Schools" (Ministry of Education of the People's Republic of China, 2003), these partnerships constitute a vital component of China's educational system. Ministry of Education (MoE) data reveals that by 2020, approved Chinese-foreign cooperative institutions and programs numbered 2,332, including 1,270 at the undergraduate level or higher. These programs educate 450,000 students—1.4% of total full-time enrollments. Through strategic partnerships between Chinese governments and higher education institutions (HEIs), these organizations merge educational resources and expertise, strengthening the national educational framework (Lin, 2016).

SFCE institutions function through a three-party governance structure: the Chinese government, foreign partners, and local Chinese institutions. Regulations require foreign institutions to maintain legal standing in their home countries, while Chinese partners must operate as recognized educational entities within China (Ministry of Education [MoE], 2003). This focus on educational sovereignty maintains consistency with national policies while introducing international academic perspectives (Lin, 2016). Scholars characterize this educational approach as "overseas study without leaving China" (Zhou & Jiang, 2019).

Student affairs officers (SAOs) serve essential functions within SFCE institutions, actively shaping student experiences and supporting academic achievement. These professionals maintain campus stability and respond to student needs, particularly within China's joint-venture university system.

The COVID-19 pandemic exposed management vulnerabilities, particularly regarding local operations during global disruptions (Jung et al., 2021; Oleksiyenko et al., 2022). China's "Zero COVID" policy, emphasizing strict case control and transmission prevention, significantly affected academic and social programs at joint-venture universities (Zhan et al., 2023). Travel restrictions further challenged operations, limiting collaboration, and affecting financial sustainability.

Current research inadequately addresses SAOs' crisis decision-making processes. China's January 2023 policy changes—reducing restrictions and eliminating quarantine requirements for

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international students—shifted priorities toward safety measures and student support services (Zhan et al., 2023). SAOs, who traditionally assist international students' college transition (Zenner & Squire, 2020), must interpret government policies to reduce crisis impacts (Gansemer-Topf, 2022) while maintaining cocurricular programs (Briggs & Ammigan, 2017). Studies during the pandemic identified challenges in health support (Starr et al., 2020; Wang & Hutchins, 2010), mobility restrictions (Mok et al., 2021), and financial pressures (Moscaritolo et al., 2022), highlighting the importance of examining crisis management in international education partnerships.

This research combines two theoretical approaches: habitual decision-making theory (Daipha, 2015) and the 4 R crisis management model (Heath, 2001). The 4R model offers structured crisis management guidance, supporting practitioners' understanding of student needs and response planning (Liu et al., 2015). While habitual decision-making theory examines choice formation in routine and uncertain contexts, the 4R model addresses systematic crisis response (Liu et al., 2015). These complementary frameworks reveal factors shaping SAOs' crisis management approaches during global challenges.

This study examines crisis management practices of student affairs officers (SAOs) at a Chinese joint-venture university during the COVID-19 pandemic. Drawing from seven departmental units, the research analyzes approaches to international student support during crisis situations. Through semi-structured interviews with 10 key SAOs, the study identifies successful strategies, areas for enhancement, and frameworks for crisis decision-making.

The research addresses two central questions:

(1) What factors contribute to SAOs' effective decision-making during unprecedented crises?
(2) How can these findings strengthen crisis management practices on university campuses?

The methodology centers on qualitative analysis of SAO experiences, examining their responses to pandemic-related challenges while supporting international students. This approach allows for detailed exploration of decision-making processes and outcomes within the unique context of a Chinese joint-venture university.

Literature Review

Conceptual Framework

This study positions COVID-19 as an institutional crisis within campus environments. While research presents various organizational crisis management models (Augustine et al., 2012), current scholarship emphasizes systematic decision-making through organizational structures. This research combines two theoretical approaches—the 4R crisis management model (Heath, 2001) and habitual decision-making theory (Daipha, 2015)—to create an analytical framework for examining campus crisis response.

Heath (2001) conceptualizes crisis management as sequential organizational actions that address crises systematically within specific contexts. The 4 R model encompasses four components: reduction and readiness, which focus on pre-crisis risk minimization and organizational preparation through structured procedures; response, which guides active crisis management implementation; and recovery, which addresses the restoration of operations and practice improvement. These components provide institutional guidelines that align with SAOs' decision-making patterns throughout crisis stages (Liu et al., 2015).

While the 4 R model charts crisis progression, Daipha's (2015) research on routine decision-making explains the reasoning behind management choices. Though originally focused on weather forecasters, her framework applies to SAOs' pandemic experiences through parallel decision-making conditions. Both scenarios involve professionals making critical decisions based on institutional knowledge within complex organizational structures. Daipha's framework identifies essential elements

of decision-making processes: pattern recognition, collaborative choice formation, systematic option evaluation, and narrative construction. These elements, grounded in Dewey's (1922) concepts of routine and adaptive decision-making, demonstrate the interplay between institutional protocols and practical decision contexts.

During the pandemic, SAOs maintained situational awareness while developing contingency measures. This study applies these complementary frameworks to analyze crisis stages through an institutional perspective. The integration of Heath's stage-based approach with Daipha's decision-making analysis provides a comprehensive lens for examining SAO responses to unprecedented challenges. This combined theoretical framework supports the analysis of crisis event categorization, decision-making processes, and institutional response patterns, emphasizing the significance of sustained crisis management in international higher education.

Internationalizing Higher Education Governance in China

The COVID-19 pandemic has fundamentally altered education systems worldwide (Jung et al., 2021). Though political internationalization transcends simple power transfers between national and transnational spheres, numerous nations have established policies promoting global student mobility (Wu, 2019). China's centralized system has demonstrated particular strengths in pandemic management, resource mobilization, and situation stabilization. Despite these advantages, studies reveal significant challenges arising from the Zero COVID policy's impact on international education, particularly in remote learning implementation (Bao, 2020), student mobility restrictions (Yang & Shen, 2022), student engagement maintenance (Ahshan, 2021), and institutional communication effectiveness (Leal Filho et al., 2021).

Shared governance within educational institutions encompasses structured staff decision-making, defined accountability measures, and clear role ownership in professional practices (Newman, 2011). Multicultural institutions organize diverse perspectives into coherent systems of distinctive approaches (Müthel et al., 2012). This research examines these dynamics within a Chinese joint-venture university, where foreign universities partner with Chinese higher education providers (Onsman, 2013). These institutions advance China's strategic initiative to strengthen higher education through foreign educational practices that align with national standards (Lo & Pan, 2021).

Joint-venture universities have developed shared governance approaches that enhance frontline staff participation in institutional decision-making. Student affairs officers navigate complex governance structures to address both domestic and international student requirements while maintaining educational standards across institutional frameworks. This governance model strengthens professional roles and distributes decision-making authority across positions, ensuring institutional actions reflect established responsibilities and expectations (Kremer et al., 2024). The Chinese experience mirrors global trends in higher education development, characterized by increasing prevalence of joint-venture university partnerships (Liu & Lin, 2012).

Crisis Management in Chinese Higher Education

A crisis, characterized as a sudden, unexpected event causing significant harm, has broad applications across disciplines (Kosellect & Richter, 2006). The COVID-19 pandemic exemplifies such a crisis, transforming political, economic, educational, and cultural frameworks globally (Yang & Shen, 2022). International higher education faced extraordinary challenges as border closures and travel restrictions disrupted student mobility and institutional collaborations (Oleksiyenko et al., 2021).

Student support specialists advocate for comprehensive approaches addressing individual student needs and strengths, promoting holistic development throughout the college experience (Gysbers, 2001). The student affairs profession emerged from academic leaders' recognition that students' non-academic needs required dedicated attention and support (Moore et al., 2023). Within American institutions, student affairs professionals foster both academic and personal development, creating

comprehensive support systems (McClellan & Kiyama, 2023). Professional organizations ACPA and NASPA recognize crisis management as fundamental for practitioners in organizational, human resources, and student support domains (Reason & Broido, 2017). These essential competencies encompass understanding emergency protocols, developing crisis response plans, and addressing student emergencies effectively.

SAOs maintain responsibility for student health, safety, and well-being while shaping meaningful cocurricular experiences (Gansemer-Topf, 2022). The pandemic transformed campus environments and student life, presenting unprecedented challenges to student affairs teams as traditional support methods required adaptation (Wang & Hutchins, 2010). Universities needed rapid responses and innovative protocols to maintain student support amid mounting uncertainty.

Crisis management addresses extraordinary circumstances through systematic approaches (Roux-Dufort, 2007; Shaw, 2018; Treadwell, 2017). The pandemic demanded coordinated responses within international education to protect students, educators, and institutions, ensuring educational continuity despite widespread disruptions (Yang & Shen, 2022). Research examining pandemic decision-making reveals significant challenges in online transitions, stakeholder safety maintenance, and rapid decision requirements (Bao, 2020; Gigliotti, 2021; Yang & Shen, 2022). This research examines SAOs' implementation of student-centered decision-making during this global crisis.

Current scholarship lacks comprehensive analysis of internationalization from student services perspectives (Ardoin et al., 2019). While studies document international students' challenges with online learning readiness and preparation (Novikov, 2020), evidence suggests improved student outcomes through enhanced self-reliance and adapted learning models (Moorhouse & Kohnke, 2021). This study advances higher education internationalization research by examining SAO decision-making effectiveness during unprecedented crises, contributing to improved crisis response practices in international education settings.

Methodology

Case study research is often used in higher education research because the college and university environment and situations occurring on campus represent the definition of a case (Creswell, 2013). This case study asked SAOs to provide feedback on their experiences between 2020 and 2023. Baxter and Jack (2008) espouse that qualitative case studies provide researchers with the opportunity to explore issues from a variety of perspectives, allowing the phenomenon to be understood more deeply. Institutional review board permission was granted on April 27, 2023 to conduct this research.

Research Site and Participants

The study centers on a Sino-American joint-venture university in an Eastern province of China, where Chinese cultural norms interlace with the American value system, presenting a rich tapestry of cultures. The institution's international students comprise 40% of the undergraduate body, hailing from 60 different countries.

Our selection of participants follows the logic of purposeful sampling (Small, 2009). We had 19 SAOs from the targeted institution respond that they would like to participate in the study. By employing a saturation sampling approach, as described by Small and Calarco (2022), we selected 10 participants who met the following criteria: (a) worked at the institution between 2020 and 2023, (b) served in the frontline team and had decision-making experiences during the pandemic, and (c) worked with international students during that time (See Table 1). This selective sample was chosen to achieve data saturation, ensuring that the most informative and relevant information was obtained for the case study. Participants held positions at various levels within the student affairs department, and all had a significant role in making decisions to support international students during the pandemic. The importance of decision-making in the role of SAOs makes these participants ideal for the context

Table 1 Participant Information

	GENDER	NO. OF YEARS IN PROFESSION	DEPARTMENT	DUTY LEVELS IN SAO
DANNI	Female	9	Student Affairs General Office	Middle level
DAW	Female	10	International Student Office	Middle level
CHRIST	Male	12	Residence Life	Middle level
JENNIFER	Female	4	Counseling and Psychological Services	Entry Level
JANET	Female	25	Student Affairs General Office	Senior level
LIN	Female	9	Campus Engagement	Middle level
MARY	Female	6	International Student Office	Entry level
PETER	Male	5	Residence Life	Entry level
VICOTRIA	Female	3	Chinese Students Office	Entry level
ZACK	Male	12	Athletic	Middle level

of this study. Given the intensity of challenges during this period, we offered flexibility in conducting interviews via Zoom video calls.

Data Collection and Analysis

Guided by Saldana's and Omasta (2016) work in conducting this qualitative study, our investigation centered on two research questions, addressed through semi-structured interviews, policy analysis, and examination of institutional correspondence. Interviews, conducted in English, ranged from 45 to 62 min, with linking between interviews and university e-mail announcements and posts to analyze why people do what they actually do (Jerolmack & Khan, 2014). The interview protocol, formulated from existing literature, included questions about participants' perspectives, experiences, decisions, and challenges in supporting international student mobility during and beyond the pandemic (e.g., describe your experiences in navigating international students to go back to their home countries in January 2020; how do you establish a stable connection with international students during the pandemic?). We also solicited policy-related documents, university announcements from the interviewees, and collected posts from institutional websites and social media that provided evidence of how the institution was managing the COVID-19 crisis in supporting international students.

We adopted a paradigmatic approach to coding, combining top-down and bottom-up methods (Erikson, 2004). After each interview, an initial analysis memo was written (Merriam & Tisdell, 2016). The first step entailed a thematic analysis of both interview transcripts and other data, allowing for open coding. We then used the 4R framework (Heath, 2001) as an analytic lens, aiding in the formation of categories and assignment of codes. In the Findings section Heath's (2001), 4R model is used as a framework for data presentation: readiness, response, recovery; reduction is highlighted in the Discussion section. This model and Daipha's (2015) theory of habitual decision-making guide the data analysis and help make meaning of the findings. The final stage of analysis focused on identifying emergent themes by combining preliminary codes with the working categories established by the theory. We combined preliminary codes that emerged from the bottom and the working categories enlightened by the theory. Likewise, we aimed at virtual lines of inquiry by combining the preliminary codes that emerged from the initial analysis.

To ensure the credibility of the research, we engaged in member-checking with study participants and had a peer reviewer scrutinize the research process (Yin, 2014). Policy documents and university announcements were used to triangulate the codes and themes identified in the interview analysis. The use of multiple data sources enhanced the overall trustworthiness of the study. Interviews and artifact analysis were performed by two independent researchers and cross-checked for reliability until consensus was achieved. Furthermore, all authors of this study occupy both insider and outsider positions, with each having either studied or worked abroad as SAOs. While the insider perspective stems from personal or professional experience at globalized institution, the outsider perspective is defined by detachment from the institution, along with objective and critical evaluation of its policies

and practices. Last, we shared the study's findings in order to seek participant validation; all ten participants affirmed the results, with none requesting change or clarification.

Findings

Combining the habitual decision-making and 4 R crisis-management models, we examined factors that enhance the decision-making effectiveness of SAOs facing unprecedented crisis. We structured our thematic analysis findings to cope with the conceptual framework, focusing on readiness for the crisis, responding to the crisis, recovery beyond the crisis, and reducing foreseeable challenges.

Readiness for the Crisis

Understand the Decision-Making Environment

Critical to the pre-crisis stage is detecting early warning signs of a crisis, taking action to address the signals before a crisis develops, and having an established plan to tackle various crises if they occur. COVID-19 caught most HEIs off guard (Moscaritolo et al., 2022). SAOs faced challenges in anticipating and planning for specific impacts on higher education. School leaders sent the initial e-mail announcement titled "Onset & Spread of the Coronavirus" on January 21, 2020. In this communication, the institutional leader acknowledged uncertainties surrounding the situation. As Peter, who is the deputy director of the student affairs office pointed out, "During the pandemic, we were the first ones to face international student mobility issues. We had a very small amount of time and resources to get a pretty glimpse of what other universities were doing." The lack of specific guidance limited the time and resources available to institutions to adequately prepare for and respond to the needs of students.

During times of crisis, decision-making authority often becomes centralized (Gansemer-Topf, 2022). However, it was equally crucial to empower key organizational personnel to make decisions at the ground level. In the case of individual SAOs, decentralized decision-making supported by shared governance strategies proves to be mutually beneficial for both the institution and its staff. For example, Janet said "In general, I work very hard to leave decision-making authority to the staff. I am showing them that I trust their judgment that I know, for a fact, they know their area better than I do." This approach reflected a broader strategy of empowering frontline staff to take ownership of decision-making. During COVID-19, the shared governance model allowed SAOs to make more informed and timely decisions tailored to the specific needs of diverse student populations with adaptive responses.

This joint-venture university has set as its primary goal to create a world-class environment that fosters liberal arts education and research, aiming to cultivate globalized citizens. As Christ described, "the institution is a quite different place and how we're organized, how we function, how we respond to things." The institution's blended Western education with Eastern culture influences the institutional structure and organizational culture on decision-making.

The institution's utilization of shared governance systems while involving different levels of staff to incorporate the voices of SAOs proved to be beneficial in navigating the uncertainties brought about by the pandemic. As Lin shared, "I was designated as 'essential staff' and live on campus with a group of students who chose to remain during the early stage of the pandemic. I also served as a staff representative on the emergency plan team, collaborating with school leaders to covey students' need and provide insights to updated policies." This shared governance process enabled school leaders to have a broader vision of students' needs and make decisions to accommodate rapid changes during the crisis.

The institution established a dedicated crisis management team that allowed for multiple voices. As illustrated by Daw, "Since I was one of six staff living on campus with students during the pandemic, I was able to bring the real concerns from students to the table." By creating a structured approach to crisis management, the institution ensured that necessary resources were available to support students and that their concerns were addressed promptly.

> We will hold on for meetings when there is major announcement on change of health guidance or updates on pandemic. By that time, the purpose is just to let students know to manage their expectations and answer their questions regard health guidance (Danni).

The decision-making environment plays a pivotal role in shaping the decision-making process (Daipha, 2015), and orients SAOs toward a service approach that prioritizes students. Understanding the institutional structure and culture allowed SAOs to accommodate the decision process in the fast-paced onset and development of a crisis. Shared governance in this joint-venture university enabled proactive measures, allowing for diverse input and practical solutions.

Strategic Understanding of Student Needs

Primary responsibilities of SAOs include providing the best support and services to students academically and socially. During the pandemic, SAOs acted as frontline service providers to address students' needs, which included support for domestic students abroad, checking that on-campus students were healthy and upholding international student mobility. Their response was characterized by a student-centered approach aimed at resolving challenges. Proactively reaching out to international students and anticipating their needs, Zack played a crucial role during the pandemic, as he stated "I generally don't like to be reactive. I like to be proactive and just foreseeing what can as many options [SIC] as possible in the future. Eventually, that was the approach I took from the beginning."

SAOs demonstrated a practical understanding of the fluidity of the situation. Extensive contingency planning was undertaken, designed with flexibility to accommodate in response to the changing landscape and the latest data. Despite facing stringent lockdown mandates, Zack championed the continuation of physical education programs, underscoring a commitment to holistic health. Like Zack, many members of the student affairs office also championed such forward-thinking strategies. He told us "We decided to continue to offer it, because when we reflected on our mission and value of our department, it really is to support student wellness, health, and balance to physical activity."

SAOs proactively engaged student representatives and organizations to ensure that students' diverse perspectives were taken into account. Through consistently held regular town hall meetings and the inclusion of student representatives in decision-making processes, the student affairs office updated COVID-19 policies regularly, highlighted the significance of protocols for students who remained on campus, and provided a platform for students to directly engage with institutional leaders. These efforts significantly enhanced the SAOs' comprehension of student's needs and preferences. Danni reported that "We held regular virtual Town Hall meetings throughout the pandemic for direct communication with students. Students get a chance to talk to the school leaders and receive emotional support."

With decisions largely centered on catering to daily student needs, along with concerted outreach and advocacy efforts, the initial reactive stance of SAOs swiftly transformed into a proactive, tailored approach.

Responding to the Crisis

Flexibility Under Restrictions

In accordance with the policies set by the MoE and local government, leaders at the institution formulated action plans to support students in leaving campus and reuniting with their family members. The decision was made due to the prevailing uncertainty surrounding the severity of the pandemic infection. Janet says "We primarily supported international students financially and logistically with booking transportation home during the pandemic. Many students and their parents were very concerned and looked to be in safety and wanted to return home."

Daw, a senior International Students and Services Coordinator, played a crucial role in accurately interpreting health guidance provided by the government and effectively communicating it to address student concerns. Daw reported that it was essential to ensure that information is

understood correctly and relayed in a clear and concise manner. The SAO team arranged bi-weekly briefings for international students, especially to disseminate updates concerning their return to China.

The process of supporting international students was challenging, requiring innovation and the consolidation of information from various offices and disseminating it through a single platform. The centralized information sharing strategy encourages students to stay informed about changes and streamline decision-making. For example, Christ said "We centralized one tech platform that all students used for academics. The platform was familiar to students and they regularly checked." Upon the interpretation of the polices, Danni kept students updated with changing travel restrictions, their implications, and the measures the institution was taking. She stressed that "we will need to calm the students and let them know our planning for the next step very quickly."

Contingency Planning in Rapid Changes

In addition to flexibility, SAOs emphasized the importance of contingency planning as they faced frequent and unpredictable changes from the pandemic. The dynamic nature of government policies required institutions to revise their approach quickly. During March 2020 to June 2022, SAOs shifted their prioritizing toward implementing health and safety measures. They assumed a new role in adapting to the new reality and quickly assessing its impact on students. The institution placed a high priority on the health and safety of its students by implementing and strictly enforcing COVID-19 protocols. In certain cases, the health guidance formulated at the national level may not perfectly align with the specific context of individual institutions. To ensure clear and accurate communication to students, Victoria took the initiative to seek clarification from local government executives. She was able to adapt the health guidance to provide the best possible support for the students. Victoria's proactive approach helped bridge any gaps between the national guidelines and the unique circumstances of the institution.

> As a front-line staff in serving and supporting students, I interpreted the updated guidance and raised some questions on behalf of students. Then, we highlighted key points for students and shared announcements to students accordingly with the institution context (Vicky).

Jennifer highlighted the necessity of robust contingency planning due to the rapid changes in government policies. The dynamic nature of these policies requires institutions to be agile and proactive in their approach. By developing comprehensive contingency plans, institutions can effectively respond and adapt to the evolving governmental regulations, ensuring continuity in providing support and services to students. Jennifer's statement underscores the importance of flexibility and preparedness in navigating the challenges posed by frequent policy changes: "The policies were constantly changing, making it difficult to stay up-to-date. What was true today might not be true tomorrow."

The unique process of delegating the responsibility of accommodating international students to partner schools allowed for better implementation of flexible measures to adapt to the new reality. This need for contingency planning extended beyond health measures to other areas of student support. For international students who were unable to return to China due to the travel restrictions the institution created innovative alternative solutions. School leaders quickly established a new study abroad program in Europe to cope with more international students' needs. Janet tells us, "For students who were not physically at the institution, a lot of them had the opportunity to study at foreign partner campus and be together at the campus and meet friends from all around the world there." This kind of forward planning allowed students to continue their academic journey without significant disruption.

In addition, the institution has a student-faculty/staff ratio of 7:1 with ample opportunities to experience individualized support in taming the struggles brought by the pandemic. Supporting this concept, Christ told us, "We have to take that big process, chopping into bite-size sizes, recognize that it's very individualized for different passports and locations."

Recovery Beyond the Crisis

Advanced Support System for Students

Throughout the duration of this study, SAOs have been fully immersed in COVID-19 communications and response efforts. SAOs have had to continuously stay up-to-date with the ever-changing health guidance, navigate differing opinions, craft messages for various communication channels, await feedback on each communication, make decisions for responses, and repeat this cycle for each subsequent set of changes. The practices reflected on the habitual part of decision-making, where decision-making becomes insightful and efficient because it is rooted in practiced ways of reasoning and execution (Daipha, 2015).

Now that all international students have returned to campus, the institution is entering the recovery stage. During this critical phase, it was vital for top-down management and communication to benefit all departments. SAOs served as strategic thought partners who can assist the institution in navigating challenges, making informed decisions, and caring for the university community during the post-pandemic transition. Their experience and expertise contributed to a successful recovery and ensured that the needs of students, faculty, and staff were adequately met.

China announced that citizens from more countries could enter China in the fall semester of 2022. However, international students struggled with balancing tensions between wanting to return to campus and the restrictive quarantine process in coming to China. The process of supporting students was challenging, requiring innovative methods for gathering and disseminating information through a single platform. This centralized information sharing strategy encourages students to stay informed about changes and streamlines decision-making.

Reduce Foreseeable Challenges

The top-down approach effectively integrates centralized communication and encourages collaborations across the campus to support students. In the transition period during recovery, the institution prepared for alternative scenarios for the upcoming summer to reduce and get ready for the uncertainty. Janet put it this way:

> While Sino-US are the dominant spaces, we also must value diversity of our global students and faculty. The richness of the fabric of the institution comes from our diversity. We always have to find ways to honor that diversity and incorporate into our practices, policies and procedures.

During the recovery stage, it was inevitable that creativity emerges, potentially reducing foreseeable challenges. SAOs have invested significant efforts in reflecting on the lessons learned during the pandemic. However, it was important to acknowledge that the true impact of COVID-19 on international higher education is still in the process of being assessed. The full extent of its success or failure in addressing the challenges and implementing effective measures was yet to be determined, as supported by Janet's comments, "It is too early to assess the impact of our efforts to reintegrate students. The generation of young adults is going to have a lasting impact from the pandemic literally in their DNA and shaping the society going forward."

Discussion and Implications

In the early stages of the pandemic, government policies were introduced to manage the uncertainty of the global crisis. Such policies caused a prolonged delay, and travel restrictions were put in place to control the spread of the virus. The Chinese government's announcement of a national lockdown intensified the situation, imposing stricter travel bans, limiting in-person activities, and complicating SAOs' efforts to effectively manage and support students.

In preparing for a crisis, the findings show that understanding the decision-making environment and strategically addressing students' needs are key factors in making effective

decisions. Under the Zero COVID policy, institutional leaders decided to restructure course instruction into online formats, and all campus engagement activities shifted to virtual programs. SAOs managed a delicate balance between following regulations and maintaining international student engagement. Respondents struggled with fluctuating travel restrictions, unpredictable quarantine procedures, and full-scale border closures. These unpredictable policies posed significant challenges to crisis readiness. The lack of guidance, combined with limited time and resources, hindered institutions' ability to adequately prepare for and respond to the needs of international students (Oleksiyenko et al., 2022). One limitation of this study is its focus on the experiences of SAOs in a specific context and may not capture the full range of challenges faced by SAOs in other regions or countries.

As the readiness stage marks a crucial period where shared governance needs to be synchronized to support the institution's transition during crisis, the findings highlight the role of SAOs as crisis managers at the ground level. Shared governance enhances crisis management by incorporating diverse perspectives. The practices foster collaboration and trust to ensure quicker and more effective responses while promoting transparent communication across the institution (Jung et al., 2021). Meanwhile, the shared governance approach increases buy-in from all stakeholders and enables smoother executions and adaptability in uncertain situations (Kremer et al., 2024). In the context of this study, we conceptualize shared governance as a model that empowers SAOs by involving them in decision-making. The SFCE model allows SAOs to take on more significant roles in crisis management with the support of senior leadership. This flexibility contrasts with the more rigid power structures seen in traditional Chinese institutions (Mok et al., 2021). It is crucial to understand students' needs in complex circumstances. Regular town hall meetings offer opportunities for students to advocate for their needs and demonstrate that the student-centered strategy is robust and effective in decision-making in the crisis context. This finding aligns with previous research (Gansemer-Topf, 2022) and underscores the values of care and student focus (Reason & Broido, 2017). SAOs, who are service-oriented by nature (ACPA, 2020), proactively addressed challenges related to communication barriers and diverse methods of engaging students. Last, shared governance in the context enables HEIs to respond quickly, communicate effectively, and make well-rounded decisions that account for cultural differences and manage crises more effectively.

Furthermore, the response stage shows that managing flexibility under restriction and having contingency plans were essential in managing the complex challenges posed by the pandemic. SAOs remained flexible under strict guidelines, and their proactive development of contingency plans ensured essential student support. Flexibility emerged as a crucial factor in the SAOs' response and recovery from the crisis. Navigating uncertainty and adapting to rapidly changing government policies and health guidance were vital in providing effective student support. Future research could explore best practices for developing flexible and adaptable crisis management strategies that apply to different institutional contexts.

In the recovery phase, it is crucial to recognize the prolonged duration of the pandemic and reduce unforeseen challenges. This calls for a flexible approach to fulfill an advanced students support system and reduce foreseeable challenges. Reflecting on SAOs' decision-making process, it is evident that they must be prepared for this reality and cannot overlook the recovery implications of their decisions (Liu et al., 2015).

Global crises often spark innovation, giving rise to more advanced and practical crisis management strategies in student affairs practices. This study highlights the importance of a student-centered approach, shared-governance, contingency planning, and flexibility in crisis management. However, further research is needed to explore the generalizability of these findings, examine the effectiveness of different decision-making models, and identify best practices for maintaining flexibilities in supporting students in transition from readiness to recovery.

Conclusion

Throughout this study, we examined specific implications concerning the evolution of higher education and the role of SAOs, focusing on improving our understanding of the factors that influence SAOs' crisis management capacity. The study proposes potential new research directions concerning crisis management in higher education. It is imperative for institutions to offer supportive and accessible policies for students, staff, and faculty during crisis scenarios. This recent global crisis provides an impetus for higher education leaders to deepen their reflections and strategically plan for a transition back to standard college operations. Enhancing our understanding of how SAOs interpret their crisis management experiences can inform professional practice. This can be achieved by improving crisis management training, facilitating SAOs' reflections on their experiences, and emphasizing decision-making as a critical component of crisis management. A micro-level study on SAOs' perspective of the pandemic's impact on international higher education can contribute to the understanding of crisis management more broadly. The empirical evidence gathered in this study also contributes to macro-level issues concerning crisis management in international higher education, such as student mobility, international collaborations with various stakeholders, and SAO professional development.

Crisis management amid uncertain policy changes demands SAOs' careful balance within and beyond campus. Navigating complex challenges to support student success, SAOs face emotional and physical stress. Joint-venture universities, guided by government policies, adopted a share-governance approach to address global crises, managing the delicate balance between regulations and international student engagement. SAOs, under such circumstances, should proactively apply student-focused services, collaborating astutely with stakeholders to communicate decision rationales. This study, while focused on a case from a joint-venture university, may not universally apply. However, the challenges in SAO crisis management and emerging developments have broader implications for future research in international higher education. The next logical step is to establish connections among crisis management factors during recovery, exploring their mutual influence. This entails a cross-institutional literature review to enhance SAO practices in international higher education.

Disclosure Statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

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